3.3 Efforts at Compromise

Who among your friends is the peacemaker? There's usually one who brings those in conflict together and tries to find common ground and iron out differences. Sometimes these efforts pay off. Sometimes they don't.

MAIN IDEA Leaders in the North and the South tried to resolve the secession crisis, but their attempts to reach a compromise failed.

THE CRITTENDEN PLAN

After South Carolina seceded from the Union, John J. Crittenden, a senator from Kentucky, tried to step in as peacemaker. In 1861, he offered a proposal that came to be known as the **Crittenden Plan**. Under the terms of this compromise plan, the federal government would have no power to abolish slavery in the states where it already existed. Further, the Missouri Compromise line would be reestablished and extended all the way to the Pacific Ocean. Slavery would be prohibited in territories north of the line, but in territories south of it, local residents would decide whether to allow slavery.

The proposal found many supporters in both the North and the South, and President James Buchanan pushed for its speedy approval in Congress. President-elect Abraham Lincoln and many Republicans, however, strongly objected to extending slavery in any new territories. After much debate, the Crittenden Plan was defeated in Congress, and the secession crisis continued.

LINCOLN BECOMES PRESIDENT

As his inauguration approached, Lincoln put together his government. For his Cabinet, he purposely chose men who represented competing factions within the Republican Party. Some of them could barely stand one another.

Surprisingly, four of the top positions went to men who had competed with Lincoln for the Republican nomination. He would later defend these appointments by saying, "We needed the strongest men of the party in the Cabinet. These were the very strongest men. Then I had no right to deprive the country of their services." Some have called the men he assembled "a team of rivals."

Lincoln took office on March 4, 1861, as the 16th president of the United States. In his inaugural address, Lincoln spoke sternly and directly about the crisis facing the country. He said his first task was to reunite the nation. Secession was illegal, he declared; no state could simply decide on its own to leave the Union. The Union was therefore

A Perpetual Union

At the beginning of his inaugural address, Lincoln stated that he was going to get directly to the point and talk about the matter of greatest concern to the country at that moment: the threat of southern secession. He assured the South that he did not support freeing its slaves. But he also emphasized that there was no constitutional basis for withdrawing from the Union.

PRIMARY SOURCE

I hold that, in contemplation of universal law and of the Constitution, the Union of these States is perpetual [everlasting]. Perpetuity [This permanence] is implied, if not expressed, in the fundamental law of all national governments. It is safe to assert that no government proper ever had a provision in its organic law [system of laws] for its own termination [end]. . . . The Union will endure forever.

—from Abraham Lincoln's First Inaugural Address, March 4, 1861

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Lincoln with his Cabinet and Generals
In this engraving from 1866, Lincoln meets with his Cabinet and military leaders to discuss their response to the South's secession. Lincoln did not want war with the South, but he wanted to be prepared for it if it couldn't be avoided.

still intact, and he vowed to use his powers as president to protect places and property belonging to the federal government. He assured the South, however, that he did not intend to interfere with slavery where it already existed, and there would be no invasion or use of force by the government. "We are not enemies, but friends," Lincoln said. "Though passion may have strained, it must not break our bonds of affection."

Lincoln's words had little effect. The day after his address, a message arrived in Washington from **Fort Sumter**, which lay at the entrance to the harbor in Charleston, South Carolina. The fort was under threat from Confederate forces, and its **garrison**, or defense force, of about 85 federal soldiers would soon run out of food. Lincoln faced the decision of whether to try to resupply the fort. He wanted to avoid conflict, but a civil war looked more and more likely.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What compromise did the Crittenden Plan propose?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** Who did Lincoln choose to be in his Cabinet, and why did he appoint these individuals?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** Why did Confederate forces threaten Fort Sumter?

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